

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

1994-08-07 • UHG • Nationale Geistige Räte

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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To all National Spiritual Assemblies

dear bahá'í friends,

we take pleasure in sharing with you news of the highly successful world forestry charter gathering held at St. James's Palace, Thursday, 28 July, in the presence of Amatu'l-bahá Rúyiyih Khánúm and h.r.h. The Prince Philip, Duke of Edinburgh, who were the two principal speakers. Amatu'l-bahá's brief and radiant address on the spiritual dimensions of the environmental challenge, which cited words of bahá'u'lláh as the inspiration for her own devotion to the environmental cause, was several times interrupted by the warm applause of her listeners. For his part, Prince Philip used the occasion to issue an urgent call for a legally binding international convention to halt reckless deforestation of the planet.

Among the more than two hundred distinguished guests at the luncheon and the reception that followed were ambassadors and other diplomats, representatives of major environmental protection organizations, and prominent personalities in government, business and the professions. The

government of the United Kingdom participated through a statement from Prime Minister John Major, read by the Secretary of State for Environmental Affairs. Messages of support and encouragement were received from seventeen governments, the one from President Bill Clinton of the United States capturing succinctly the vision that animated the gathering, that, in the protection and sustainable management of the earth's forests, there are no borders.

The idea of regular gatherings to focus government and media attention on preservation of the world's forests was begun in 1945 by Dr. Richard S. Barbe Baker, a well-known member of the bahá'í faith and an internationally renowned pioneer in the field of ecology. The tradition was revived on the one hundredth anniversary of his birth in 1989 by the bahá'í inter-

national community acting in collaboration with the international Tree
foundation (formerly “men of the Trees”), the worldwide fund for Nature,
the United Nations environment program, and Dr. Baker’s literary execu-
tor, Mr. Hugh Locke.188.1

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1993–1996 • The Three Year Plan

□11Bahá’í leadership in the initiative won generous praise in the address
given to this year’s gathering by His Royal Highness and in several messages
from heads of state and government.

You are welcome to share this information with the friends in your
community.

With loving Bahá’í greetings,

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Progress of the Mount Carmel Project Fund

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]